Imports into Barygaza are listed by the *Periplus* and include: gold, silver, brass, copper, lead, perfumes and ‘various sashes half a yard wide’. Italian and Arabian wine was also imported in large quantities. The Indian love of imported alcohol is clearly not new. Furthermore, the manual informs us that the local king ‘imported’ luxury items such as good-looking women for his harem. Exports included spikenard, ivory, onyx stone, silk and, most importantly, cotton textiles. Cotton textiles have remained a major export from this area till modern times.

The second route to India was a more southerly one that went across from Socotra to the Kerala coast. The most important port in this area was Muzaris (or Muchheri Pattanam) that is mentioned frequently in both Graeco–Roman and Indian texts. A variety of goods were traded in Muzaris but the most important item of export by far was pepper, a spice that is native to the southern tip of India. It must have been exported in very large quantities because it was commonly available as far as Roman Britain.

For a long time historians had debated the exact location of this great port of antiquity. Excavations between 2004 and 2009 have identified it with a village called Pattanam, 30 km north of Kochi. Archaeologists have dug up a large number of Roman coins, amphorae and other artifacts in the area. It would remain a major port till it was destroyed by a big flood on the Periyar river in 1341 AD. The main trading hub then shifted to Kochi, but the Muzaris area retained enough strategic importance for both the Portuguese and the Dutch to maintain a fort there. When I visited the site in October 2011, the fort was being excavated by the Archaeological Survey. The oldest extant structure, however, is the Kizhthali Shiva temple that is said to have been built by the Chera dynasty in the second century BC. The dragons carved into the steps in front of the shrine strongly reminded me of the temples of South East Asia. Has this style made its way from Kerala to Java or the other way around?

During ancient times, an overland trade route from Muzaris and other Kerala ports made its way through the Palghat Gap (a gap in the Nilgiri mountain range near Coimbatore) to inland cities like Madurai or further on